start, the commission went to the Franco-British team of Le Corbusier, his cousin Pierre Jeanneret, Fry and Drew.

There were failures, of course. Even Le Corbusier's ardent fan Charles Correa had to admit that "the Assembly chamber is an unhappy place to step into, and it is a near impossible Parliament to deliberate in", but added: "So Corb has his failures; yet somehow, in so glorious an architecture, they do not seem to matter."

The triumphant success lay in the training of Indian architects, realising Nehru's hope that Chandigarh would be a living architecture school. These torchbearers of Modernism included Eulie Chowdhury, Balkrishna Doshi, Jeet Malhotra, Aditya Prakash and Shivdatt Sharma. The last part of the Indian section of this exhibition focuses on the work of some of them and includes Raj Rewal's Hall of Nations (1972) in New Delhi's Pragati Maidan. This complex of exhibition halls commemorated the 25th anniversary of Independence and included a memorial pavilion to Nehru as a symbol of his vision of a secular and progressive India. Rewal himself describes his practice as "modern architecture with Indian roots, with an Indian ethos" and the fact that, despite a campaign to save his Hall of Nations, its demolition in 2017 made headline news in India and internationally says much for the success of Nehru's ambition. ■

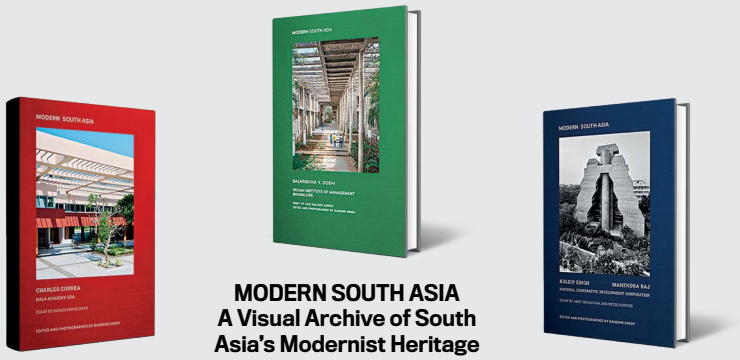
–Charles Hind

Tropical Modernism: Architecture and Independence is on at the Porter Gallery, Victoria & Albert Museum, South Kensington, London, until September 22, 2024

BOOKS

VISUAL CONSTRUCTS

CLASSICS OF MODERN SOUTH ASIAN ARCHITECTURE ARE PORTRAYED IN THESE VOLUMES PHOTOGRAPHED BY **RANDHIR SINGH**



MODERN SOUTH ASIA
A Visual Archive of South Asia's Modernist Heritage
Edited & photographed by Randhir Singh
ARTHSHILA TRUST; **₹2,000 each**

Architectural photographer Randhir Singh's three books–part of a nine-volume series–celebrating modern architecture in South Asia are odes to three landmark architectural projects (and their celebrated architects) that are exemplary specimens of modernist expression in India and assertions of the country's robust nation-building process.

The first book is a visual exploration of the iconic Indian Institute of Management Bangalore, a masterpiece designed by a visionary of modern Indian architecture, Balkrishna Vithaldas Doshi. Through the lens of the photographer, we get to experience the architect's interpretation of the spatial language of traditional Indian courtyard houses and temples into an inspired contemporary structural vocabulary. Our gaze walks into climatically responsive passageways, rhythmic paths and stairways that have been deliberately 'taken over' by nature and light. The photographer's eyes eschew all hierarchy of built geometry, to show the trees and foliage sinuously usurping and coiling over it to create a remarkable organic building–part forest, part institution.

The second book of the series reveals to our habit-blurred eyes the architectural marvel of the National Cooperative Development Corporation headquarters building in New Delhi. A collaborative effort between architect Kuldip Singh and engineer Mahendra Raj, the arresting

Our gaze walks into climatically responsive passageways, rhythmic paths and stairways that are 'taken over' by nature and light

zig-zag, gateway-like building is "an exemplary structure of late-modern architecture in South Asia and beyond". The photographs create a strong representation of the building's 'brutalist' character, its powerful concrete materiality. The photographer then also attempts to 'humanise' the structure by locating it in its street geography and peopling its severe majesty with street vistas, foliage and the occasional human presence.

The third book is a monograph on the Kala Academy, Goa, a hub of cross-cultural exchange envisioned by Charles Correa. Much like the architecture itself, the seemingly functional images stay clear of compositional ornamentation to show the building's open-to-sky spaces and intersecting semi-public zones that are set in an ingenious tropical modernism. Most striking are the images of the painted foyer where the space seamlessly extends into the perspectives of the street vistas and quadrangles painted on the walls, creating a theatrical illusion the visitor becomes a part of.

Magnificently produced and printed along with insightful essays, these books evoke the marvel of these modern buildings. The photographer, with a 'trained' restraint keeps the creative flourish a notch lower than the expression of the built spaces, allowing them to transcend their utilitarian ends and acquire auras of design and art. ■

–Bandeep Singh